

HR.com's Future of Coaching and Mentoring for Leadership 2026



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through better coaching
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MARCH 2026

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Executive Summary

When it comes to leadership, today's organizations suffer a serious priority paradox. That is, they claim to prioritize leadership and leadership-development practices such as coaching and mentoring. But leadership development is badly underperforming because most leaders are not trained, rewarded or recognized for developing other leaders.

At the start of 2026, the HR Research Institute polled HR.com members and found that leadership development will be among the top three important HR-related issues over the next 12 months. Moreover, we found that 71% of respondents with leadership coaching programs agree that coaching is a strategic priority for their organizations.

And yet, a mere 22% of respondents gave their organizations high marks (8 to 10 on a 10-point scale) when asked about the degree to which their leadership coaching improved their organization's performance!

This is the essence of the priority paradox. Most organizations claim to prioritize leadership but are reportedly not getting much benefit from leadership coaching and mentoring programs.

Why?

There are many factors, but among those that stand out are the fact that only:

- 35% say coaching and mentoring are linked to leadership performance reviews
- 30% say their organizations effectively train leaders how to coach and mentor
- 23% say participation in these programs is monitored and evaluated
- 18% say leaders are rewarded or recognized for developing others

About the Survey

HR.com's "Future of Coaching and Mentoring for Leadership 2026" survey ran from November 2025 through February 2026. We gathered responses from 177 HR professionals in virtually every industry vertical. The majority of respondents were located in North America. The participants represent a broad cross-section of employers, ranging from small businesses with fewer than 50 employees to enterprises with 20,000 or more employees.

The good news is that some organizations excel at leadership coaching and mentoring, and we can learn much from them. In this report, we call these organizations leadership-coaching high performers, or LC high performers. These organizations are, for example, much more likely to prioritize coaching in succession planning, train leaders in coaching, leverage digital learning content, and simply expect leaders to actually coach. Throughout this report, we compare the leadership coaching high performers with another cohort called leadership coaching low performers.

Organizational leaders are, of course, in a unique position relative to coaching and mentoring. They are often “receivers” of coaching/mentoring from other leaders and outside resources. At the same time, they are also the primary “givers” of coaching/mentoring. Unless an organization somehow creates strong cadres of leadership coaches and mentors, there will almost inevitably be a paucity of good leaders in the future. In other words, organizations will be caught up in a negative leadership feedback loop.

This is a particularly bad place to be circa early 2026. After all, thanks to increasingly powerful artificial intelligence, the so-called “hard skills” associated with many leadership positions (e.g., financial analysis, capital allocation, statistical reasoning, technology fluency) are arguably less important than the soft skills such as trust building, emotional intelligence, clear communication. Yet, leadership coaching and mentoring are largely about helping future leaders develop these soft skills. This is the essence of the priority paradox. Most organizations claim to prioritize leadership but are reportedly not getting much benefit from leadership coaching and mentoring programs.

Therefore, organizations that are poor at leadership coaching and mentoring will be a growing business disadvantage in coming years. They can no longer wait to get leadership development right.



Major Research Findings

Major Finding 1

While coaching and mentoring are priorities for most organizations, there are, at best, mixed reviews when it comes to business success.

- Among organizations that engage in leadership coaching or mentoring, 71% agree or strongly agree that coaching is a strategic priority in their organization. A majority (59%) feel the same way about mentoring.
- However, only 22% say that, to a high degree, leadership coaching has improved their organization's performance, and only 21% say the same for mentoring.
- On the positive side, leaders are expected to coach and mentor others (55%). However, only 30% of leaders are trained in how to coach and mentor effectively and 18% rewarded and recognized for developing others.

Major Finding 2

Several factors are driving the usage of coaching and mentoring now and in the future.

Top reasons for coaching/mentoring **today** are:

- building leadership capability
- accelerate leadership readiness/succession planning
- increase organizational performance
- improve leaders' current performance
- help leadership coaching lower performers
- manage organizational change

Top reasons for coaching/mentoring in the **future** are:

- improve organizational performance
- strengthening the leadership pipeline
- creating positive organizational culture
- prepare leaders for new roles or assignments
- prepare leaders for emerging changes

Major Finding 3

Coaching/mentoring is done by a mix of inside/outside resources.

- Respondents indicate that most coaching is done by direct supervisors (30%), trained people inside the organization (18%), and executive or senior managers (17%).
- On the other hand, most of the mentoring is done by non-direct managers (25%), and executive/senior managers (23%).

Major Finding 4

A low percentage of respondents placed greater importance on sponsorship programs in the near future.

- One in four agree or strongly agree that sponsorship programs will become more important over the next two years.
- Key characteristics of sponsorship programs currently in place include:
 - ▶ sponsors act as informal coaches/mentors (25%)
 - ▶ sponsors advocate for leadership development (26%)
 - ▶ sponsors help leadership coaching lower performers sponsees have access to coaching/mentoring resources (21%)

Major Finding 5

The top barrier to effective coaching and mentoring is not having sufficient time.

- 58% of respondents indicate that there is not enough time to coach/mentor, followed by a lack of budget/resources (52%).
- Less frequent barriers are the skill levels of those doing coaching (19%) and recipients of coaching/mentoring being resistant to change (14%).

Major Finding 6

The majority of organizations fail to measure the Impact of leadership coaching/mentoring.

- One in four organizations do not measure the impact of coaching/mentoring at all.
- Metrics that are used by over one-in-three organizations are participant feedback (42%), goal attainment (38%), leadership behavior change (37%), leadership performance improvement (36%), and engagement levels (34%).

Major Finding 7

Coaching/mentoring skill levels are weak.

- Out of a list of ten coaching skills, there were only two areas where a majority of leaders were rated as proficient: Sharing knowledge and expertise (62%) and building rapport and trust (57%)
- Some of the areas where coaching skill levels were less proficient included listening to gain a better understanding (47%), instilling confidence (39%), and practicing empathy (39%)
- When it comes to mentoring, only one was above a majority: sharing knowledge and expertise (73%).
- Especially weak mentoring skill levels include giving useful feedback (47%), listening to gain a better understanding (43%), instilling confidence (38%), and practicing empathy (29%).

Major Finding 8

While there is some prevalence of using AI to facilitate coaching and mentoring, adoption is slow.

- Thirty-two percent use no technology at all to facilitate coaching/mentoring.
- Of those that do use technology, only two applications were chosen by 30% or more: digital learning content (40%) and integration with other HR systems (30%).
- Weaker technology skill areas include automated administration (29%), in-session support tools (29%), data analytics (28%), and integration with other HR talent systems, and structured program management (23%).

Major Finding 9

There are considerable differences between organizations that excel at coaching and mentoring (higher performers) and those that do not (lower performers).

- Higher performers have a stronger culture conducive to coaching/mentoring:
 - ▶ leaders well-trained in coaching/mentoring skills (49% vs. 14%)
 - ▶ coaching/Mentoring built into succession planning (39% vs. 16%)
 - ▶ leaders are expected to coach and mentor (67% vs. 45%)

How Effective Are Leadership Coaching and Mentoring Programs?

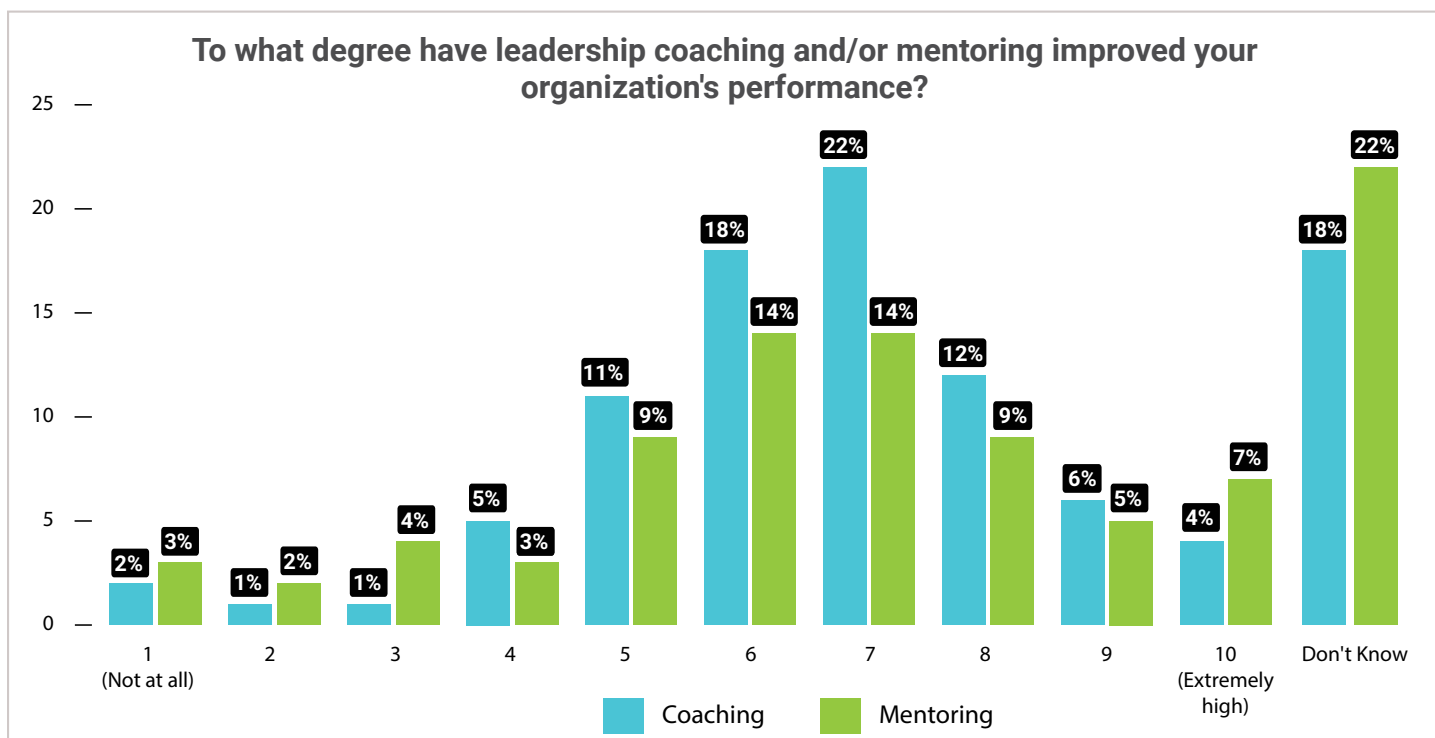


Finding: Only a fraction indicates that their leadership coaching and mentoring programs have improved their organizational performance to a high degree

Although most organizations with formal leadership coaching programs consider them strategic priorities, only 22% believe that their coaching programs have improved their organizational performance to a high degree (that is, 8 to 10 on a 10-point scale). A similar trend can be seen with mentoring programs.

Moreover, around a fifth of these respondents simply don't know how leadership coaching and mentoring are affecting organizational performance, suggesting that they do not have solid ways of measuring the impact of those programs.

Later in the report, we will examine data indicating why many organizations do not feel as if they're getting a high performance return on their investments in these programs, and we will highlight practices that might serve to increase the effectiveness of leadership coaching and mentoring.



About one-fifth do not know the performance impact of their leadership coaching and mentoring programs

About Leadership Coaching High Performers and Leadership Coaching Low Performers

We wanted to analyze the differences between those organizations with, according to self reports, more highly effective leadership coaching initiatives and those with less effective ones. We started by dividing our sample into two cohorts:

- Leadership Coaching Higher Performers (LCHPs):** Those respondents who rated the degree to which leadership coaching had a 7 or above on a 10-point scale for the question, "Taken as a whole, to what degree has leadership coaching contributed to business success in your organization." By using the 7 to 10 standard (as opposed to the 8 to 10 one), we were able to bring in a more statistically significant group of respondents.
- Leadership Coaching Lower Performers (LCLPs):** Those respondents who rated a 6 or below to the leadership portion of the same question. We then took a closer look at some of the key differences between these two cohorts in terms of strategies and approaches, with an eye to discerning possible best practices.

Of course, correlation is not the same as causation. While we cannot state that any practice will lead to success, we do see intriguing relationships that may result in greater success.

How Prevalent and Prioritized Are Leadership Coaching, Mentoring and Sponsorship Programs?



Finding: Although many organizations have formal leadership coaching or mentoring programs, a large proportion still do not

Sixty-nine percent of organizations have a formal leadership coaching program, and 62% have a formal mentorship program. Among those with a formal coaching program, most have had it in place for at least a year, and 31% have had one in place for five years or more.

Similar percentages also apply to leadership mentoring programs. Of these organizations, 27% have had a mentoring program in place for five years or more, while 33% have had a program in place for less than five years.

While most organizations have coaching and mentoring programs underway, a considerable percentage of organizations lack any formal coaching or mentoring initiatives. As we will discuss later in this report, they are potentially missing out on numerous benefits that can be realized by putting these programs in place.



Editor's note: If respondents stated that their organization had neither a formal coaching or mentoring program, they did not answer other questions in the survey. Those who responded "don't know" were removed from the data set. They represented 3-4% of respondents.



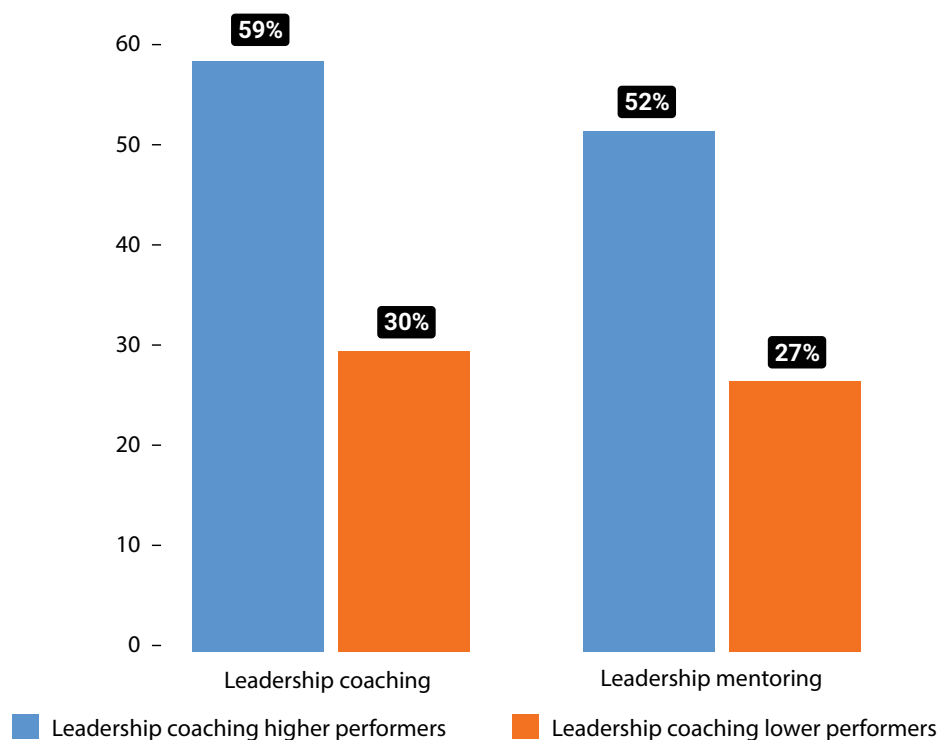
More than 30% have no formal coaching or mentoring programs



Finding: LC higher-performing organizations are two times more likely to have a coaching or mentoring program in place for five or more years

Higher performing organizations are more likely than lower performing organizations to have leadership coaching programs in place for more than five years (59% vs. 30%). The same applies to mentoring (52% vs. 27%). It appears length of time may be related to the effort it takes to put excellent programs in place.

Percentage of organizations that have had programs for leadership coaching and/or mentoring in place for more than five years





Finding: While sponsorship programs are less common, sponsors act as informal coaches and mentors and advocate for leadership development opportunities

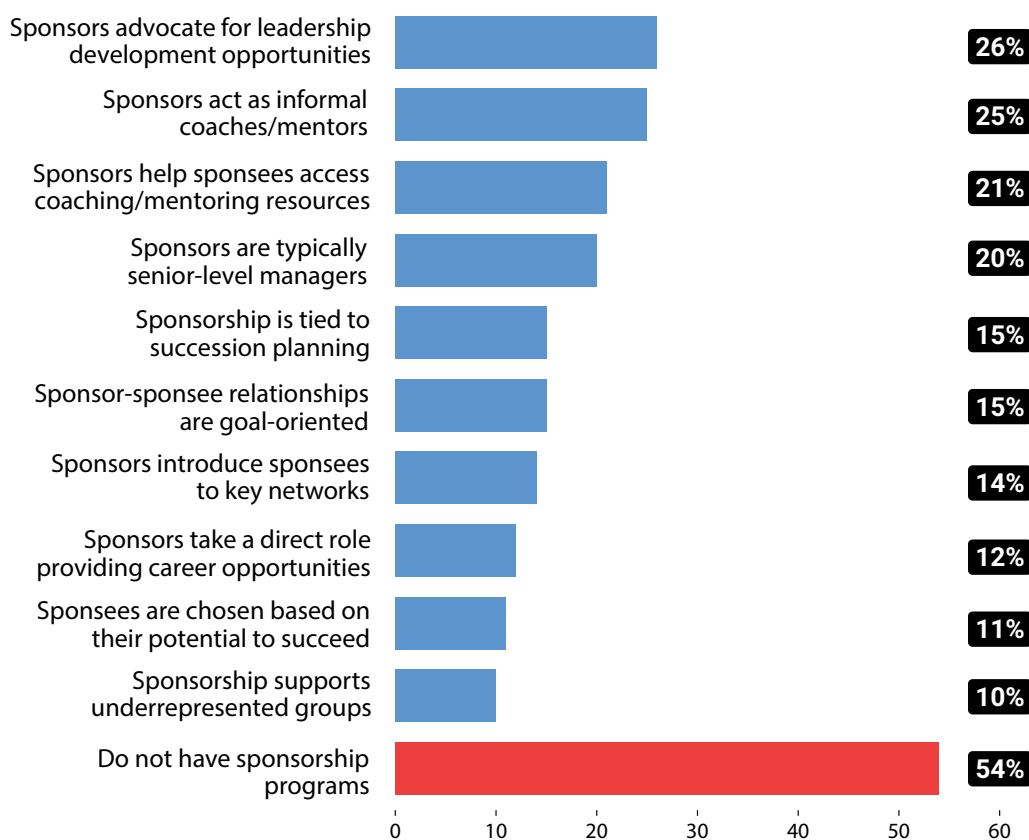
Slightly more than half of respondent organizations with leadership and/or mentorship programs do not also have sponsorship programs. The graph below shows the major characteristics of sponsorship programs for those that do have them in place.

The top three characteristics of such programs are:

- sponsors advocate for leadership development activities (26%)
- act as informal coaches/mentors (25%)
- sponsors help sponsees access coaching and mentoring resources (21%)

Which of these are characteristics of sponsorship programs in your organization?

(select all that apply)





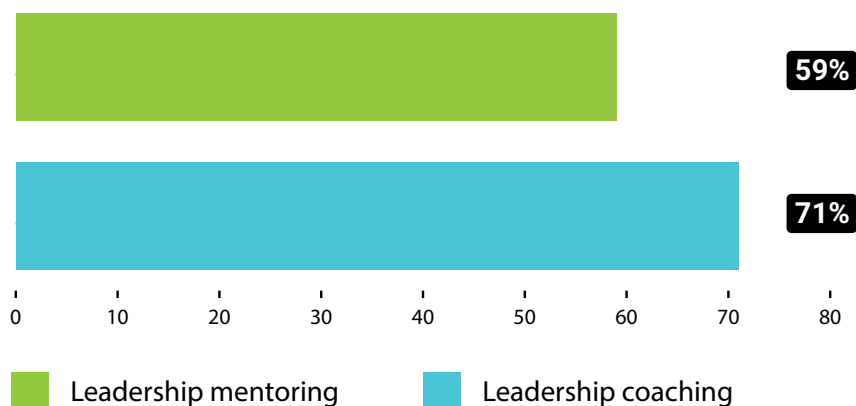
Finding: Most organizations consider leadership coaching and mentoring programs a strategic priority

Most organizations recognize the strategic value of coaching and mentoring in leadership development. Seventy-one percent agree or strongly agree that coaching for leadership development is a strategic priority for their organization. A lower percentage (59%), however, identifies mentoring as a strategic priority.

Although the proportion of organizations prioritizing these initiatives is relatively high, there remains considerable room for improvement, particularly in elevating the status of mentoring.

Coaching and/or mentoring are currently strategic priorities in your organization.

(Percent responding "agree" or "strongly agree")



The Drivers of Leadership Coaching and Mentoring



Finding: The top reasons to engage in leadership coaching and mentoring are to build leadership capabilities, accelerate readiness and improve performance

We asked respondents to pick the top five reasons driving leadership coaching and mentoring from a list of eleven. The top two were building leaders' capabilities (64%) and accelerating leadership readiness (54%). Some of the other reasons chosen by respondents include boosting organizational performance (53%), improving leaders' current performance (50%), and helping leaders manage change (41%).

Taken together, these factors highlight the multifaceted benefits that coaching and mentoring bring to improving leaders' ability to meet current job challenges while creating a stronger pipeline of leaders for the future.

That said, only 30% cite the need to build a coaching culture among leaders, a factor that we believe is extremely important to the future success of leadership.

What are the top five reasons your organization uses coaching and/or mentoring for leaders? (select up to five)



Only 11% cite leaders' mental health and well-being as a top reason for using coaching/mentoring

How Do Organizations Support Coaching and Mentoring?



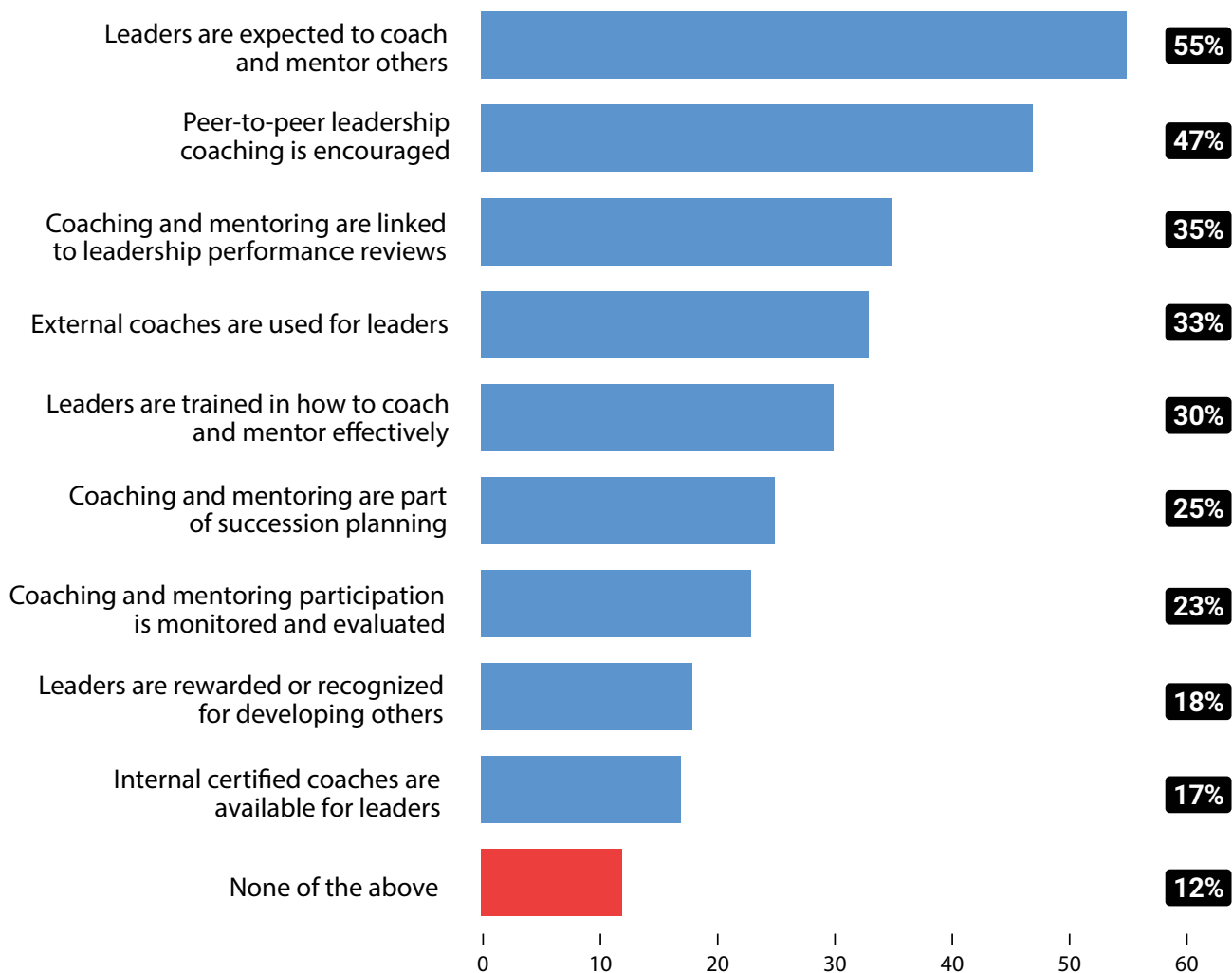
Finding: Few organizations are doing enough to support a culture of leadership coaching and mentoring

We asked about nine practices that serve as a basis for a culture that supports leadership coaching and mentoring. Only one is used by more than half (55%) of organizations: that is, “leaders are expected to coach and mentor others.” Considering that all these organizations have a formal leadership coaching and/or mentoring program, even this number is strikingly low. The only other practice chosen by close to half (47%) of respondents is the encouragement for peer-to-peer coaching.

Even more worryingly, only 30% of leaders are trained in how to coach and mentor skills effectively. Although some leaders are natural coaches and mentors, we believe most are not. Like almost all leadership skills, these are learned and practiced over time.

Moreover, few organizations reward and recognize leaders for developing others (18%), monitor and evaluate coaching and mentoring programs (23%), or make coaching and mentoring part of succession management (25%). Together, these practices are indicative of a strong coaching culture, which is clearly absent in most organizations.

Which of the following describe your organization's culture regarding leadership coaching and mentoring? (select all that apply)



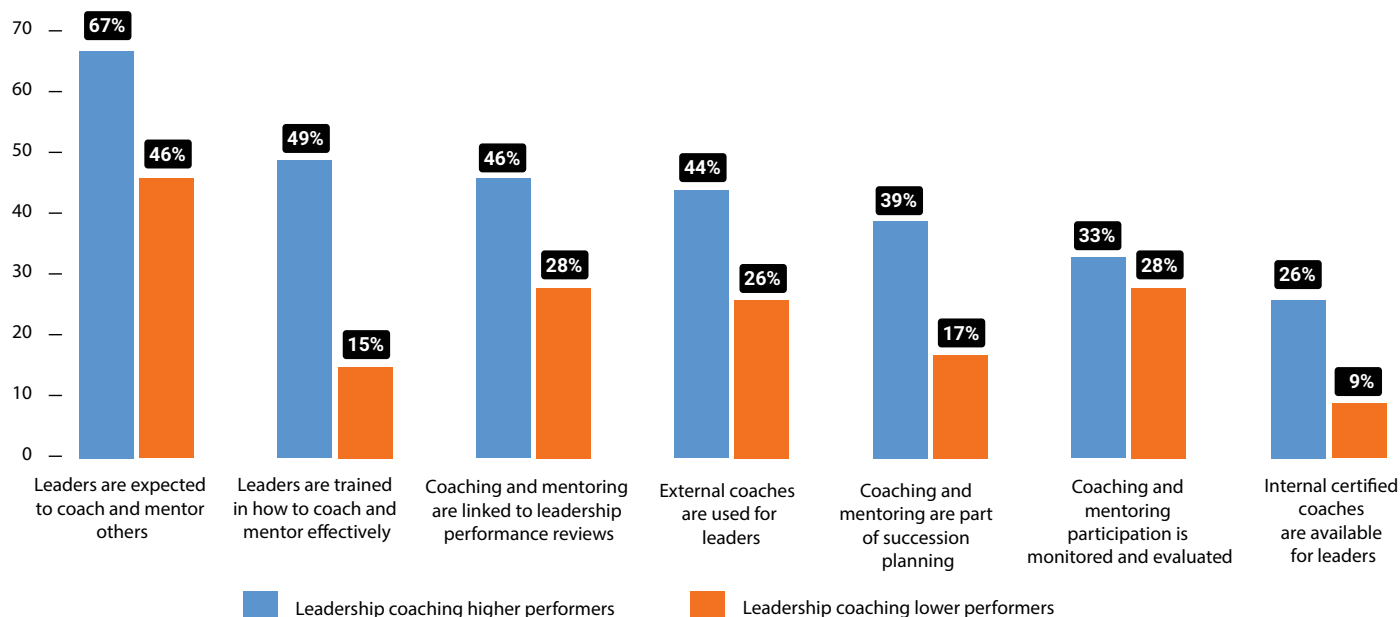
Just 30% say leaders are trained in how to coach and mentor effectively



Finding: LC higher performers are far more likely than lower performers to have a culture that supports coaching and mentoring

Leadership coaching higher performers have better coaching and mentoring cultures. In every category shown in the graph below, leadership coaching higher performers are more likely to leverage these practices. For example, 67% of higher performers indicate that leaders are expected to coach and mentor others versus just 46% of lower performers. The differences are even starker in some other areas. For example, leadership coaching higher performer organizations are over twice as likely to view coaching and mentoring participation as part of succession planning (39% vs. 17%).

Which of the following describe your organization's culture regarding leadership coaching and mentoring? (select all that apply)



Higher performers are over three times more likely than lower performers to say their leaders are effectively trained in how to coach and mentor



Finding: Direct managers are most likely to coach and indirect managers are most likely to mentor

Our research from previous years shows that there's a difference between "coaching" and "coaches." Although direct managers often coach their direct reports, they are less often viewed as formal coaches.

This year we asked study participants about who does leadership coaching in their organizations and we discovered that the most widely cited answer was direct supervisors, chosen by 30% of respondents. Other less widely chosen coaching sources include trained people within the organization, executives/senior managers, and experts from outside the organization.

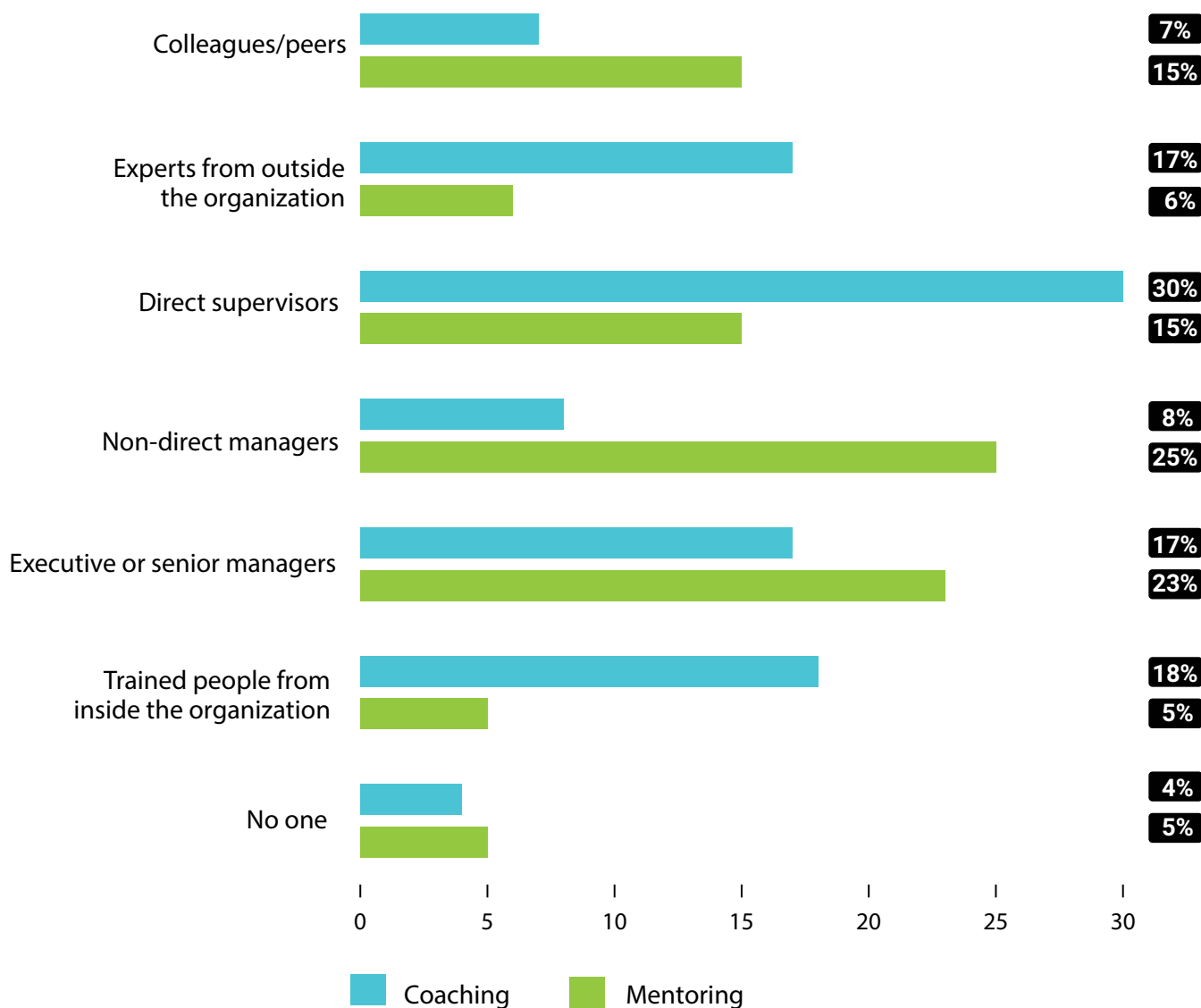
Mentoring, on the other hand, is most frequently done by non-direct managers (25%) and executives/senior managers (23%).

What explains these differences? Direct supervisors are typically able to observe direct report performance, making coaching more relevant and scalable. In contrast, leadership mentoring seems more present at higher levels of the organization, where non-supervisory senior leaders serve as mentors. These mentors provide more strategic and career-development advice to mentees whereas coaches, at least at the direct supervisory level, offer employees more practical, workday recommendations about how to do their jobs better.

Who does the most coaching and mentoring for leaders/prospective leaders in your organization?

(select the response that best applies)

Note: By "non-direct managers" we mean managers who do not directly supervise the coachee or mentee.



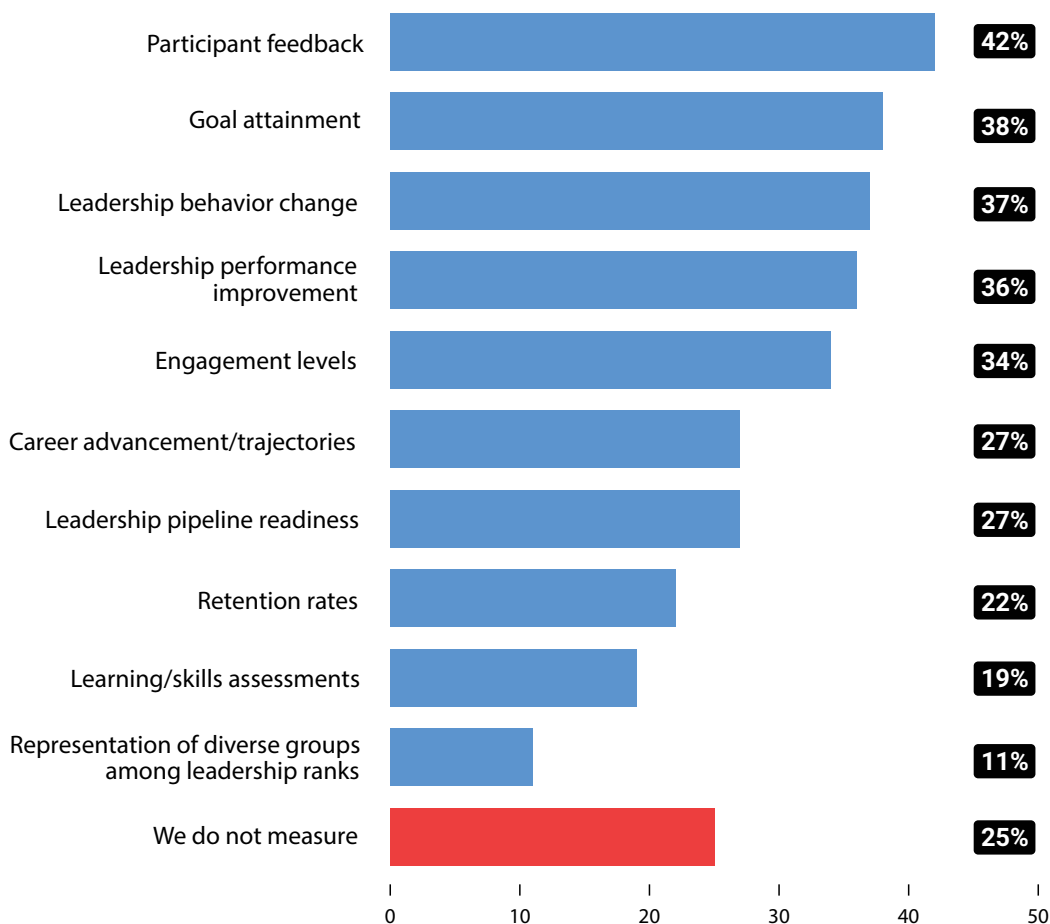


Finding: Participant feedback is the most common measure of the impact of leadership coaching and mentoring

There is no consensus about the best way of measuring the effectiveness of leadership coaching and mentoring.

Out of a list of 11 metrics, the most widely used measurement method is feedback from those being coached (42%). The other most common metrics include goal attainment (38%), leadership behavior (37%), leadership performance (36%), and engagement levels (34%). Moreover, a quarter of respondents say their organizations do not measure leadership coaching and/or mentoring at all.

How does your organization measure the effectiveness of its leadership coaching and/or mentoring initiatives? (select all that apply)

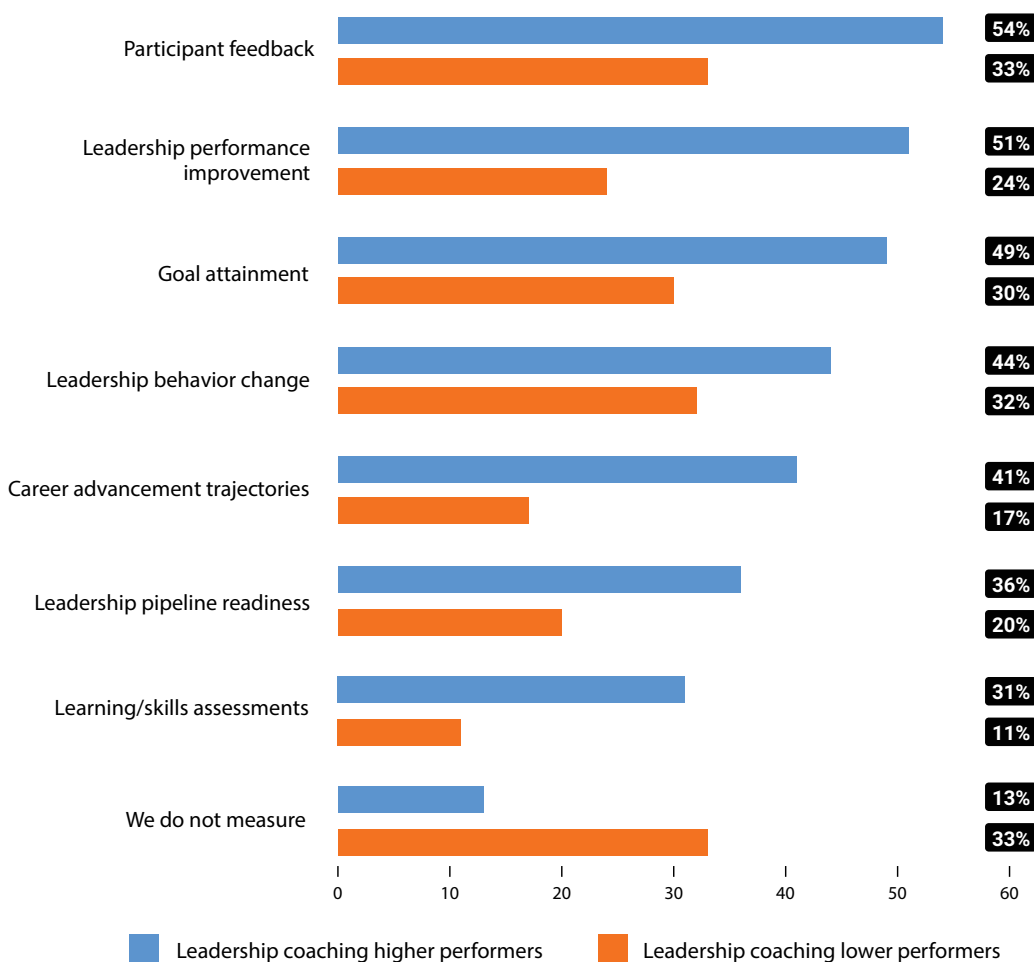




Finding: Higher performing organizations are much more likely to measure the effectiveness of their leadership coaching and mentoring programs

Generally speaking, there are considerable differences between the leadership coaching higher and lower performers when it comes to measurement. There are especially large differences in the areas of leadership performance improvement (51% vs. 24%), career advance trajectories (41% vs. 17%), and learning/skills assessments (31% vs. 11%). Meanwhile, leadership-coaching lower performer are nearly three times more likely to say they do not measure these initiatives at all.

How does your organization measure the effectiveness of its leadership coaching and/or mentoring initiatives?



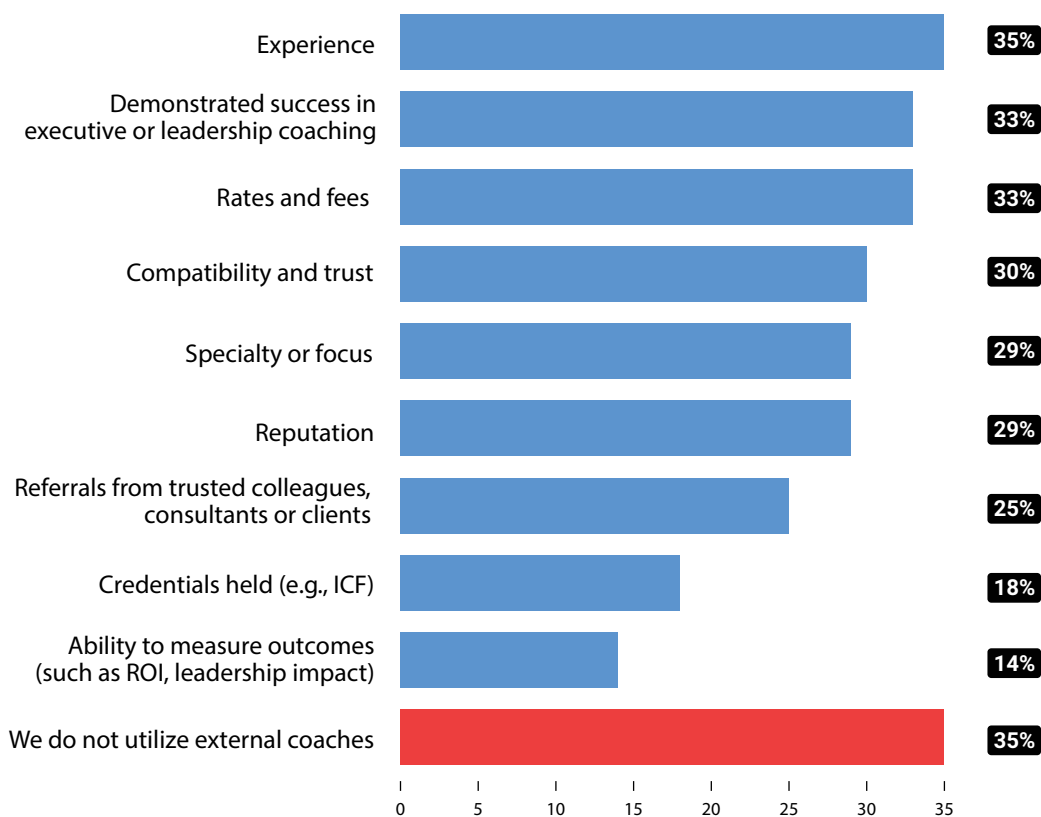


Finding: Experience is the top criteria for hiring external coaches

For organizations that use external coaches, experience is the most common criterion (35%). Rounding out the top answers are:

- demonstrated success in executive and leadership coaching
- rates and fees
- compatibility and trust
- specialty or focus
- reputation

What are the top 5 criteria your organization uses to hire or contract external coaches or coaching services for leaders/prospective leaders? (select up to 5)



Over one-third of respondents do not use external coaches at all

Challenges and Effectiveness of Coaching and Mentoring

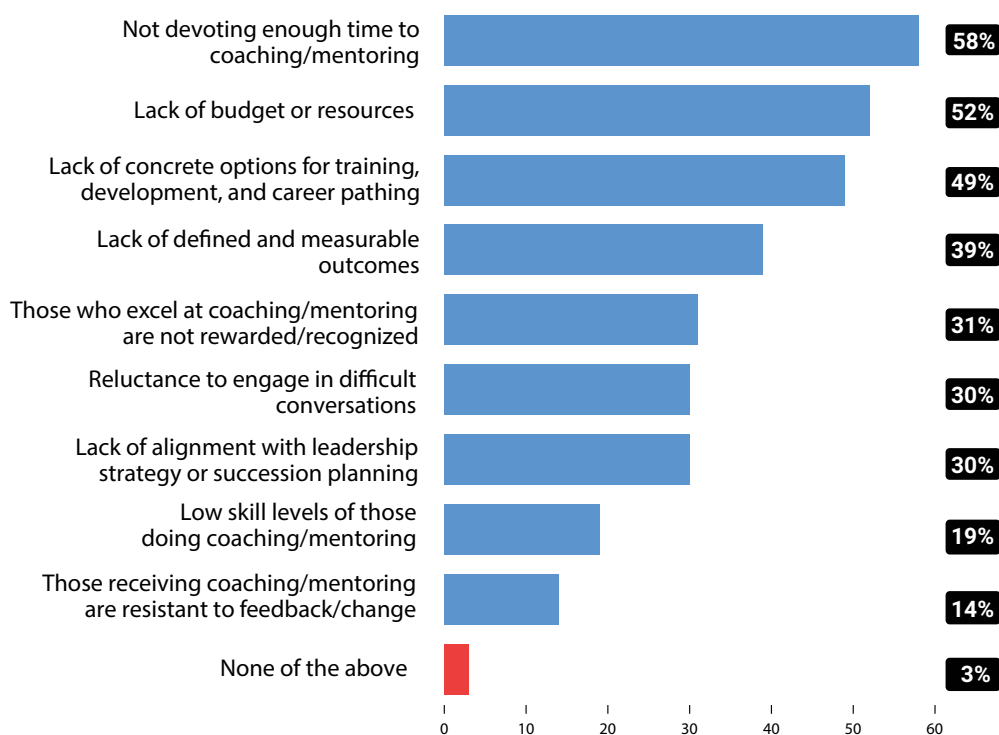


Finding: The most common hindrances to coaching and mentoring are time and budget

We asked respondents to identify the top five hindrances to leadership coaching and/or mentoring. Number one on the list, chosen by 58%, is the failure to devote enough time, followed by the lack of a budget/resources (52%) and a lack of concrete options for training, development and career pathing (49%).

These and other findings suggest a lack of commitment to coaching/mentoring, likely from the top of the organization. After all, it is typically leaders themselves who control essential components such as budget and time, including time for training and development. This is another coaching Catch-22: leadership doesn't get better until leaders themselves prioritize coaching and mentoring.

Which are the top 5 challenges currently hindering coaching and/or mentoring for leaders in your organization? (select up to 5)





Finding: Sharing knowledge/expertise and building rapport and trust are the skill areas in which both coaches and mentors display the most proficiency

We asked participants to select those skills in which coaches and mentors displayed the greatest proficiency. While there are some differences between the skills associated with coaches and mentors, most of the strongest skills for coaches were also the strongest skills for mentors.

For example, sharing knowledge and expertise was rated as the highest proficiency level for both coaches and mentors (62% and 73%, respectively). The same applies to building support and trust (57% and 51%, respectively).

The bad news, however, is that fewer than half of respondents indicated that their coaches and mentors were especially proficient in critical areas such as listening, recognizing positive behaviors, instilling confidence or facilitating strategic thinking. This isn't just bad news for coaching and mentoring. It's bad news for leadership in general.

This begs the question: If coaches and mentors are not strong in these areas, how are they going to help those they are coaching/mentoring to build higher levels of proficiency in the same areas?



In which of the following skills do leadership coaches in your organization demonstrate the greatest proficiency? (select all that apply)



Editor's note: The 10% who responded 'don't know' were removed from the data set and responses were recalculated

In which of the following skills do leadership mentors in your organization demonstrate the greatest proficiency? (select all that apply)



Editor's note: The 4% who responded 'don't know' were removed from the data set and responses were recalculated



Finding: Coaches and mentors in the higher performing organizations are more highly skilled overall

In the graphs below, we highlight the five strongest skills among leadership coaches and mentors in higher performing organizations and compare them to the skills of those in lower performing organizations. Leadership coaching higher performers tend to have superior skills in most of the areas. For example, whereas 57% of respondents from higher performing organizations say “listening to gain a better understanding” is among the greatest proficiencies of their leadership coaches, the same is true for only 29% of those from lower performing organizations.

In which of the following skills do leadership coaches in your organization demonstrate the greatest proficiency? (select all that apply)



In which of the following skills do leadership mentors in your organization demonstrate the greatest proficiency? (select all that apply)





Finding: Effective communications is the competency most targeted for development through coaching/mentoring

We asked participants about the five leadership competencies their organizations are most focused on developing via coaching and mentoring. Two-thirds say effective communication across people and groups, the only response selected by over half.

We have witnessed this high prioritization of communication in other HR Research Institute reports. In fact, this is also the skill that HR professionals themselves are most likely to prize.

Which five leadership competencies are your organization most focused on developing through coaching and/or mentoring? (select up to five)



How Is Technology Changing Coaching and Mentoring?



Finding: Technology enables coaching and mentoring but roughly a third don't use technology for this purpose

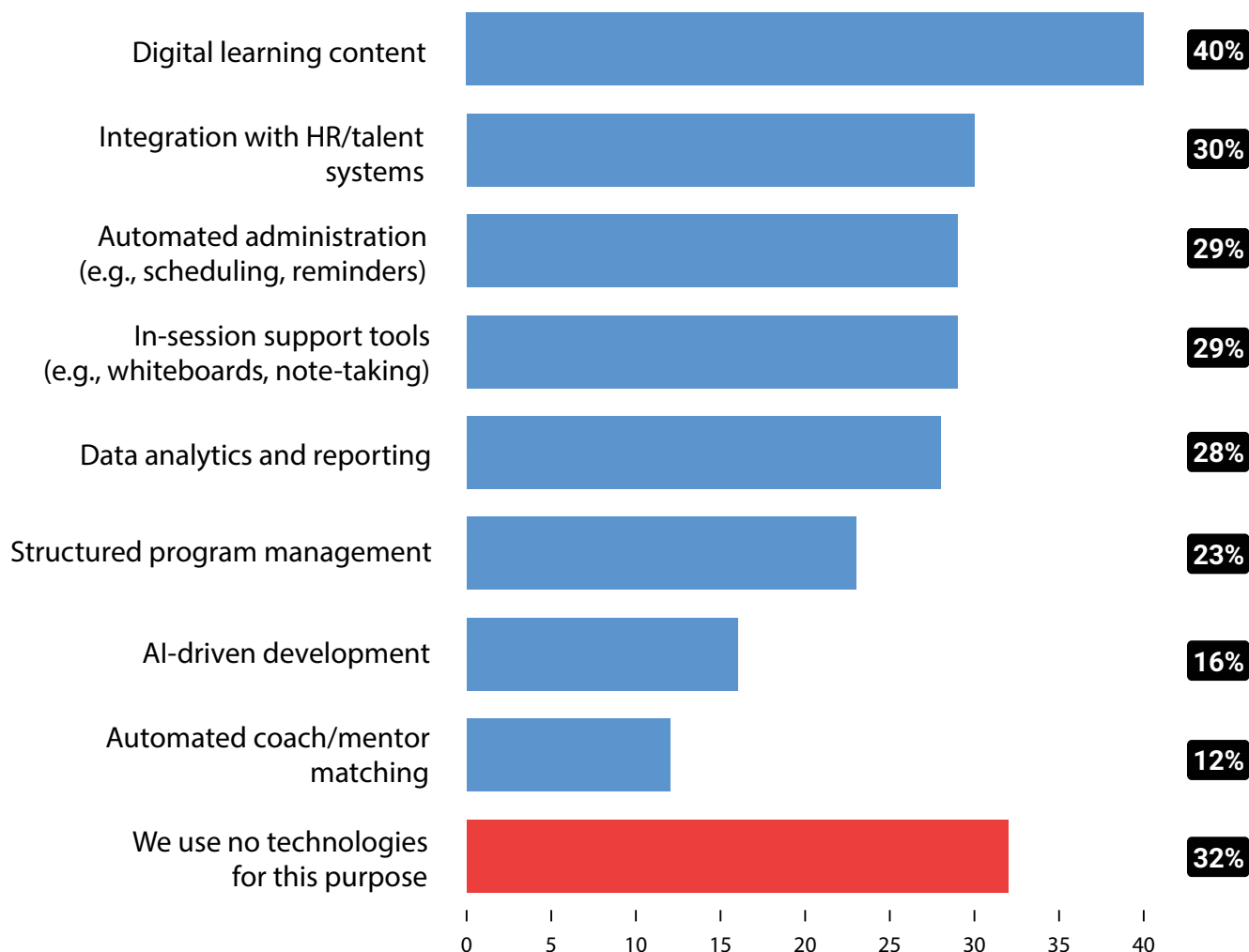
Coaching tends to be highly personalized both to coach and to the coachee. These are typically one-to-one relationships and they often occur face-to-face. So, it is not a surprise that about a third of respondents do not leverage any technology to facilitate coaching and mentoring.

That said, most companies do leverage technologies in some way, with the most common being the broad category of digital learning content (40%), followed by integration with HR/talent systems (30%), automated administration tools such as schedulers (29%), and in-session support tools such as whiteboards (29%).

Despite implementation of forms of generative AI in many other parts of the HR function, only 16% say they leverage AI-driven development. Even fewer say they leverage automated coach/mentor matching (12%).



In your organization, which of the following capabilities are provided via technology to facilitate coaching and/or mentoring? (select all that apply)

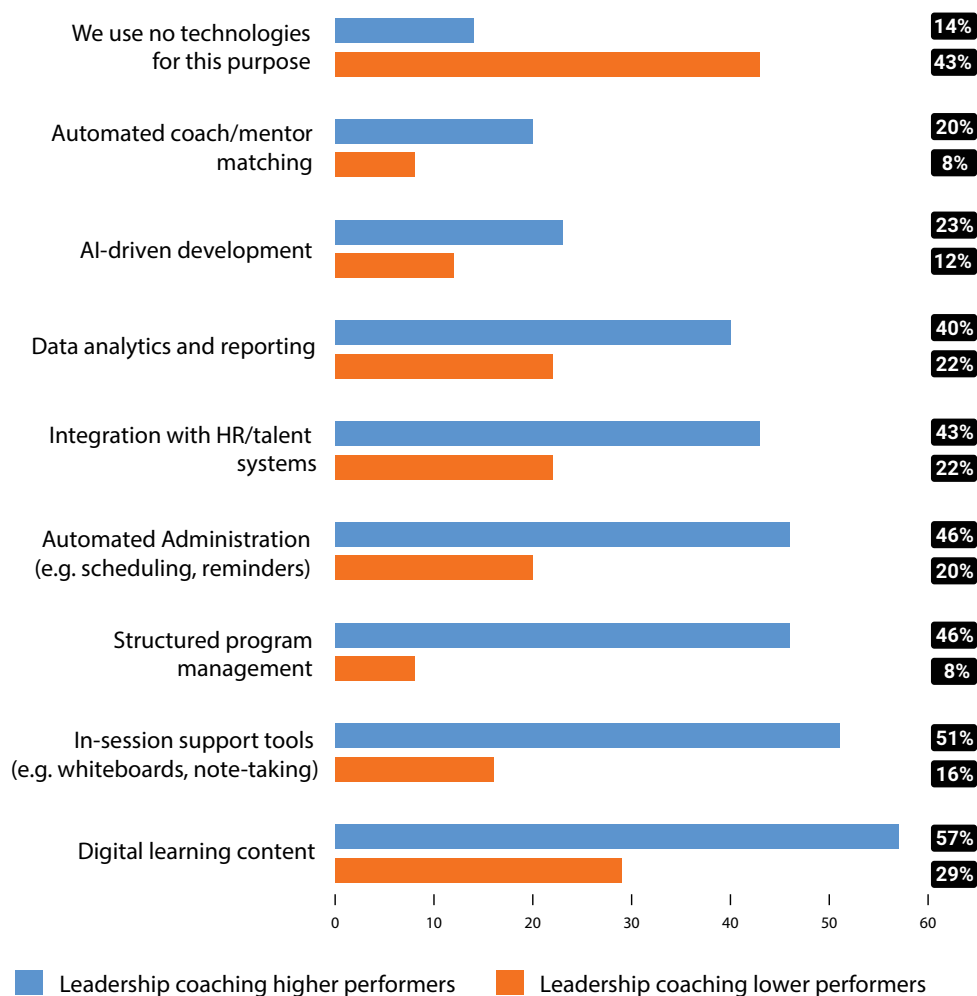




Finding: Higher performers are far more likely to adopt technology for coaching and mentoring

Compared to their lower performing counterparts, leadership coaching higher performers are far more likely to use technologies for coaching and mentoring. For example, 57% of the leadership coaching higher performers use digital learning content and 51% use in-session support tools. The numbers for lower performers are, respectively, just 29% and 16%. In other words, leadership coaching high performers are nearly twice as likely to use digital tools and over three times more likely to use in-session support tools. Leadership coaching lower performers, meanwhile, are about three times more likely to say they don't use technologies at all for coaching and mentoring.

In your organization, which of the following capabilities are provided via technology to facilitate coaching and/or mentoring? (select all that apply)





Finding: AI is slowly gaining traction in leadership coaching and mentoring

We asked respondents what role AI is likely to play in coaching and mentoring in their organizations over the next year. Nearly a fifth (18%) say they don't know and 13% say it will play no role at all.

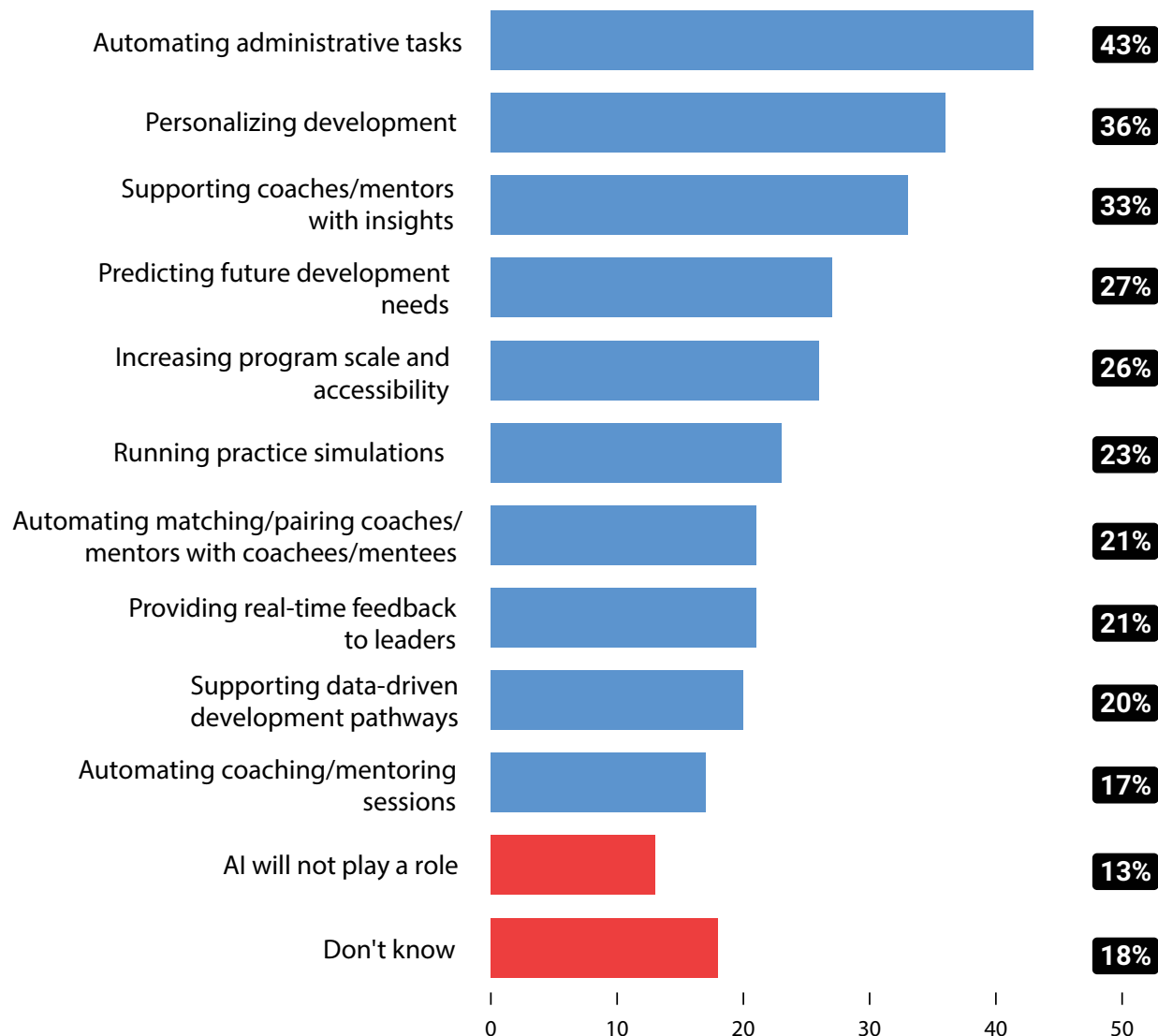
The largest group (43%) foresee AI playing a key role in automating administrative tasks. Over a third (36%) anticipate that it will help personalize development, and a third believe it will support actual coaches/mentors with insights to help make their own coaching/mentoring more effective.

A key question, of course, is: will AI replace human coaches and mentors? Only 17% foresee their organizations using AI to automate coaching/mentoring sessions.

We believe that completely replacing coaches and mentors with AI is unlikely but that more organizations will indeed leverage AI to complement their human counterparts. AI is likely to get better and better at providing coaching tips and advice tailored to needs of future leaders. However, human expertise and relationships will likely remain essential for complex, emotionally charged, or high-stakes leadership development.



In the area of coaching and/or mentoring, what role is artificial intelligence likely to play in your organization over the next year? (select all that apply)

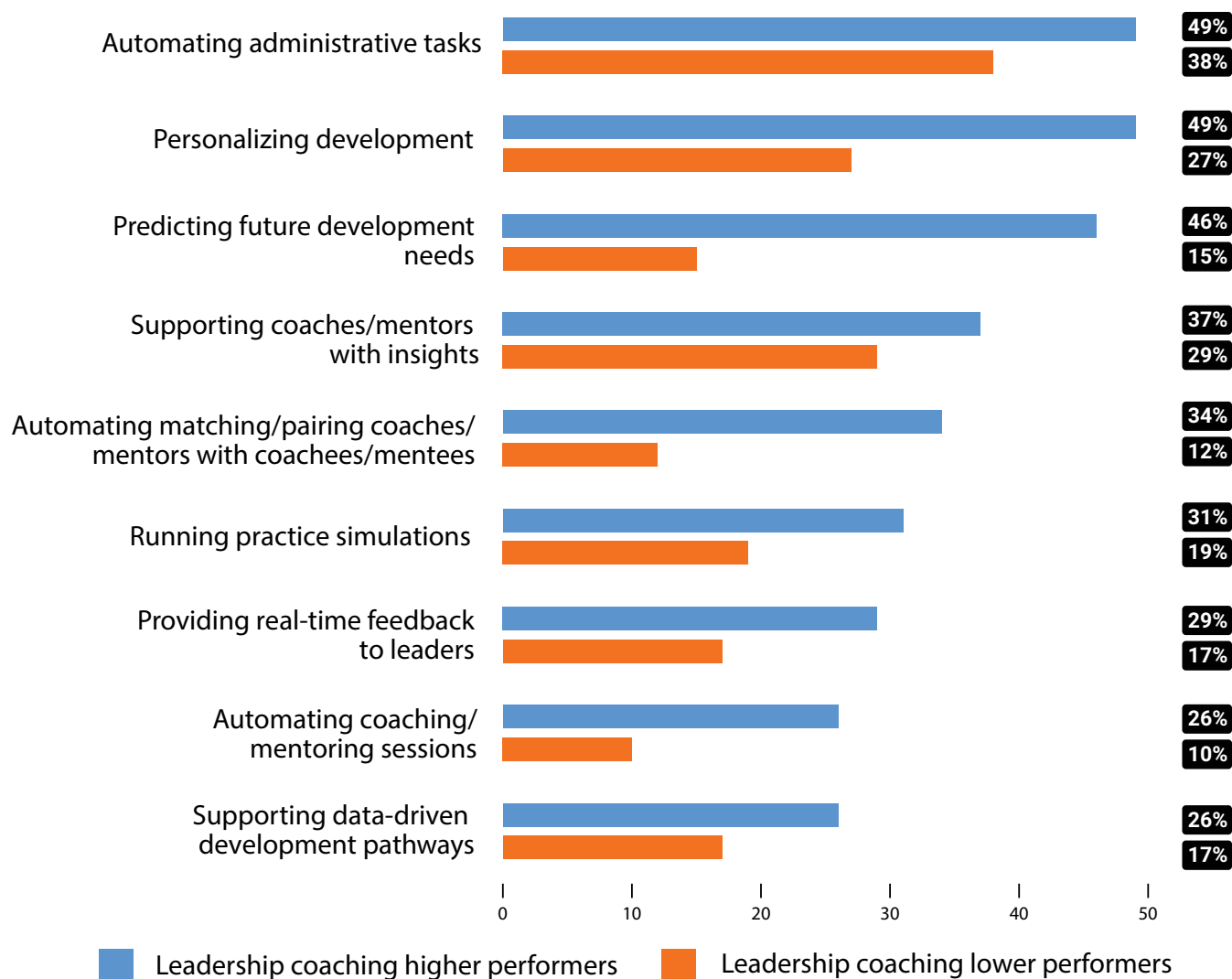




Finding: Leadership coaching higher performers have greater expectations around AI than their lower performing counterparts do

Leadership coaching higher performers seem to have bigger plans for AI than lower performers. They are three times more likely to say AIs will be used to predict future development needs and to automate the matching of coaches with coaches. Higher performers are also about twice as likely to say AI will be used to personalize development and over twice as likely to say AI will be used to automate coaching and mentoring sessions. To get feel for how AI may be used for coaching and mentoring, please see the callout box.

In the area of coaching/mentoring, what role is artificial intelligence likely to play in your organization over the next year? (select all that apply)



Cloverleaf: AI Coaching insights in the flow of work

"AI is a humongous opportunity for HR to actually turn all their existing investments into highly personalized development for every single employee every single day in their flow of work," according to Kirsten Moorefield, co-founder of Cloverleaf, a platform that unites assessments, personalized coaching, and team insights.

The Cloverleaf platform aims to solve the problem of team dynamics and organizational silos by combining disconnected HR data (i.e. performance reviews, courses, behavioral assessments, etc) into coaching insights that are delivered directly into a user's "flow of work" through collaboration and communication tools.

While some development tools measure impact through login rates and usage, Cloverleaf looks at specific areas employees are working on, such as confidence or leadership, and it tracks that real-time behavior change across teams and the organization. "People who engage in our AI Coaching are 3 times more likely to get promoted and gain direct reports," says Moorefield, who started Cloverleaf with partner Darrin Murriner in 2018 well before the public launch of today's generative AI models such as ChatGPT.

Many HR professionals show a growing interest in adopting AI as a way of personalizing development for employees, but that doesn't mean they are not concerned about potential problems related to data and employee privacy.

"We are strong believers that every individual owns their data," Moorefield says. Employees get to choose what information gets sent back to their managers. And any data that does get sent to leadership is examined through aggregated reports.

Cloverleaf aims to make professional development an organic and daily part of the employee experience, one that aids communication within organizations. Moorefield states, "So much of our miscommunication is actually an opportunity for us to understand more information and to understand a different way of seeing the problem."



TalentMotives: Scaling Leadership by Understanding Intrinsic Motivations

You may remember Michael Scott, the fictional terrible boss from the TV comedy “The Office.” The character is funny partly because he’s based on something that’s all too common in today’s organizations: a bad manager who used to be a good individual contributor in their field of expertise.

Ryan Dalton, COO and Chief Product Officer at TalentMotives, refers to this problem as the “Michael Scott Paradox” and views his company’s products as one way of addressing it. That is, the TalentMotives platform is designed to discern and measure the intrinsic motivations of users to help coaches better understand their coachees.

Whereas the fictional Michael Scott is often oblivious to the actual needs of his team, coaches and managers who use TalentMotives receive a clear window into each employee’s motivations and advice on how best to guide them given what drives them.

“Intrinsic motivations are foundational,” Dalton explains. “They influence your personality, which then influences your behavior.”

At the core of the platform is the Motivation Quotient (MQ), a proprietary assessment that measures 30 internal drivers. By quantifying these “high-frequency motivations,” TalentMotives helps leaders understand what provides an employee with “grit” and what saps their energy. To make this data actionable, the company introduced LiDi AI, a retrieval-augmented generative model. Unlike general AI tools that offer “cookie-cutter theoretical” advice, LiDi AI provides coaching insights strictly tied to an individual’s MQ results.

Dalton says this transforms the coaching landscape. For example, managers can use LiDi AI to prepare for difficult conversations, asking the AI for specific scripts or approaches tailored to an employee’s unique motivational profile. This personalized approach avoids the “disingenuous” feel of standard management techniques.

The business impact is measurable and long-lasting. Dalton notes that while “you can get quicker results by carrot and stick, it won’t last.” By aligning roles with internal drivers, TalentMotives was able to help one client organization, for example, reduce turnover by over 30%. Moreover, the platform moves leadership coaching from an occasional luxury to a daily, human-centric utility, ensuring that managers aren’t just hitting key performance indicators, but are truly “connecting people to understand each other better.”

The Future of Leadership Coaching and Mentorship

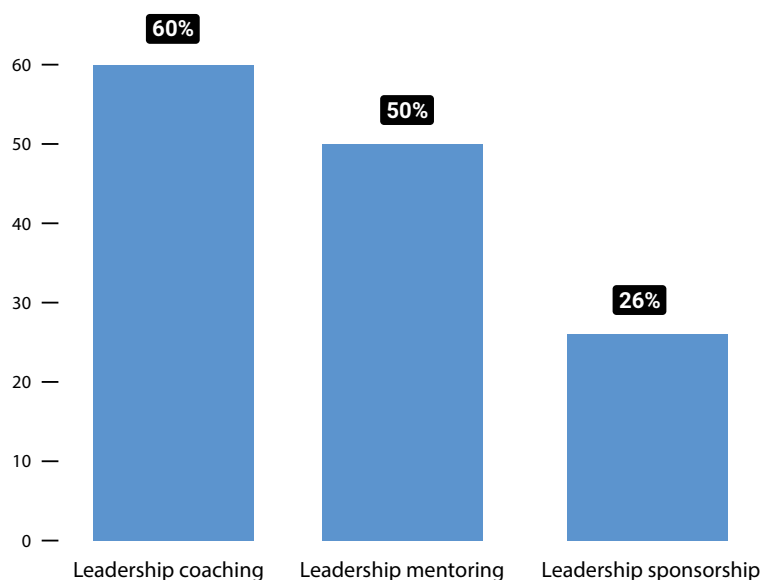


Finding: Leadership coaching and mentoring will play a larger role in the future

Looking forward, most organizations anticipate that leadership coaching and mentoring will become increasingly important over the next two years. A majority of respondents (60%) either agree or strongly agree that their organization will place greater emphasis on leadership coaching in the near future. Half indicate the importance of mentoring in leadership development will also grow.

We also gathered some data on the importance of sponsorship programs in our study. Sponsorship programs connect senior leaders (who tend to be sponsors) with high-potential individuals (that is, sponsees). While it overlaps with coaching and mentoring, it is fundamentally different. Sponsors are strong advocates for their sponsees, creating opportunities for high visibility, providing career guidance, and placing them in strategic assignments. However, fewer respondents foresee sponsorship programs becoming more important over the next two years.

Percent of respondents who agree or strongly agree their organization will place greater importance on these programs in the next two years

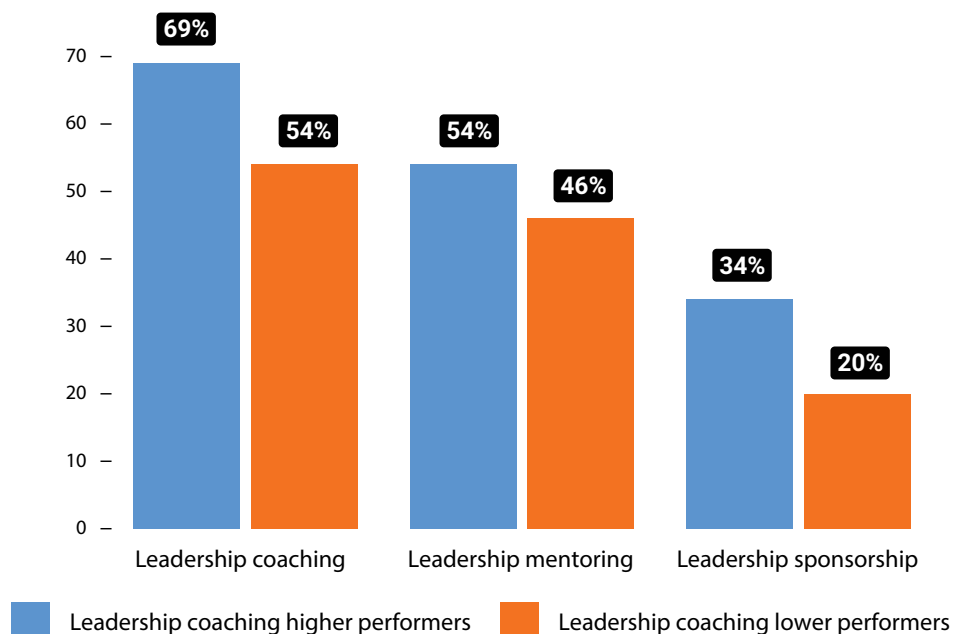




Finding: Leadership coaching higher performers are expected to place more importance on leadership coaching, mentoring, and sponsorship initiatives over the next two years.

Higher performers are more likely say their organizations will place greater importance on coaching, mentoring, and sponsorship programs over the next two years, suggesting that they will gain further advantage over their lower performing counterparts.

Percent of respondents who agree or strongly agree their organization will place greater importance on these programs in the next two years





Finding: Improving organizational performance and strengthening their leadership pipeline are the top two reasons for using coaching and mentoring in the future

What will be the top reasons for leveraging coaching and mentoring programs for leaders over the next two years? Improving organizational performance and strengthening the leadership pipeline topped the list, chosen by 63% and 55%, respectively. Other reasons chosen by most respondents include creating a positive culture (53%), preparing leaders for upcoming new roles/assignments (52%), and preparing leaders for emerging changes such as AI (49%).

Organizations do not just want to fill a leadership pipeline. They want to ensure that the new leaders have the knowledge and skills needed to adapt their organizations to a new business environment. This raises the question of whether current leaders are capable of developing the future leaders for a new age.

Indeed, if organizations decide that changes in leadership behavior are necessary to their long-term survival, they will need to find the kinds of coaches and mentors who can inculcate these changes. This could be where external coaches and other forms of leadership instruction come in. That is, for an organization to change its organizational DNA, it may need help from outside sources.

What will be the top 5 reasons for using coaching/mentoring programs for leaders in your organization over the next two years? (select up to 5)



Key Takeaways

Key Takeaway 1

Build a supportive leadership coaching culture. Coaching and mentoring are most successful when they are embedded in a supportive organizational culture. A supportive culture is one where leaders are expected, encouraged, and even rewarded for coaching and mentoring others. It is also one where leaders are trained in an array of coaching skills and seek out coaching and mentoring for themselves. To nurture this kind of culture, organizations must garner senior support, model key coaching practices and skills, and reinforce to the entire organization the value of coaching and measuring.

Key Takeaway 2

Measure impact. A quarter of organizations with coaching and mentoring programs don't measure their impact at all, which makes it nearly impossible to improve them. Basic metrics worth tracking include participant feedback, goal attainment, leadership behavior change, and whether the leadership pipeline is actually strengthening over time.

Key Takeaway 3

Turn your leaders into skilled coaches. Most organizations assume leaders know how to coach and mentor. Yet, fewer than half of leaders are rated proficient in listening, instilling confidence, or practicing empathy. Skill-building in this area needs to be deliberate, practiced, and ongoing, and leaders should be recognized for improving at it.

Key Takeaway 4

Make the best use of technologies that facilitate coaching and mentoring. Technology can take real work off coaches' plates, by scheduling, progress tracking, matching, and surfacing useful data. AI tools in this space are still early-stage but improving. Organizations seeing the best coaching outcomes already use digital learning content and in-session support tools at roughly twice the rate of lower performers.

Key Takeaway 5

Choose where you spend your coaching/mentoring time. Coaching is most effective with people who are actively trying to grow. High-potential employees often get overlooked in favor of underperformers who may not be receptive. Targeted assessments can help identify who's most likely to benefit, making the time investment more productive.

Key Takeaway 6

Use external coaches and mentors selectively. External coaches are expensive and can't realistically support an entire organization. They're most valuable in specific circumstances: senior executives navigating major transitions, situations requiring confidentiality or impartiality, or when the organization needs expertise it can't provide internally. Experience, track record, and cost are the most reasonable selection criteria.





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